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COMMENTARY

Top Ten Global Risks for 2026

The top global risks of 2026 show an ever more unstable world

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Artificial Intelligence, Grand Strategy

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Introduction

The Risks

Trump's Economic Morass

Probability:

The Dissolution of Order

Probability:

US Pivot to Western Hemisphere

Probability:

Third Nuclear Era

Probability:

Gen Z Rebellion

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Introduction

Every year since 2017, we have given our predictions for the greatest threats facing the world. If some of the top risks this year seem to echo those we anticipated for 2025, it is not that they are static, but that the peril continues, without reaching a denouement. The risks of a Trump presidency we feared have come faster and thicker than we envisioned for Gaza, Ukraine, and climate. China and Taiwan are not among the top geopolitical risks, as we judge 2026 is unlikely to see tensions rise to that level in the aftermath of the [summit](#) between U.S. President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping.

The world remains in a protracted interregnum, still unsettled, fragmenting, but no less contested. The National Security Strategy [makes](#) the U.S. retreat from primacy official: “The days of the United States propping up the entire world order like Atlas are over.” The old neoliberal rules-based architecture is decomposing, power diffusing, and much of the world is searching for new multilateral arrangements to act as a buffer against three predatory, revisionist major powers.

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...ations (G20, the G7, G20 climate summit and G-20), and a lack of global unity have fostered worries of a rogue America out to destroy itself and the system it created. Trends are not pointing toward others picking up the pieces, able to renew a rules-based liberal, multilateralist order.

This ninth edition of our annual foresight exercise, “[Top 10 Global Risks](#),” is drawn from our forecasting experience at the National Intelligence Council. In the language of intelligence, we have medium to high confidence in all the probabilities we have assigned to each of the risks, given the “credible” to “high-quality” level of information that is available. As it is for [intelligence estimates](#), a “high or medium confidence” judgment still carries the possibility of it being wrong.

The Risks

Trump’s Economic Morass

Probability:



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...collapse to know how many companies were reeling in financial distress. First Brands, an auto parts maker that filed for bankruptcy in 2025, examined how it used money that was due from customers to borrow from lenders several times over. First Brands's collapse was also spurred by the growing weakness of middle-class consumers no longer able to maintain or purchase new vehicles.

The situation is frighteningly reminiscent of what happened in 2007-08 when the holders of cheap mortgages could not keep up their payments. The [K-shaped economy](#), with just the wealthiest 20% of U.S. households fueling consumption, is not sustainable. Tariffs are beginning to increase inflation, and low hiring levels have led to an affordability crisis. Trump has few solutions beyond eliminating his own tariffs on food items such as coffee, negotiating with Big Pharma to lower drug costs, and promising \$2,000 checks for most Americans that would boost U.S. debt already equaling [around 125%](#) of GDP, a level unprecedented for peacetime.

A financial crisis this time around could be far more lethal for U.S. power in the world than in 2008. China and the G-20 are unlikely to help a second time. The U.S. dollar, already weakened, would not be the shield it has been without the U.S. taking drastic action to cut spending and raise taxes.


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making role for itself in global affairs. Europe appears paralyzed by its nostalgia for the liberal order, but Russia's invasion of Ukraine and Trump's weakening of U.S. security guarantees as stated in his recent [National Security Strategy](#) are forcing Europe to arm itself for a realpolitik world.

Yet for many states, multipolarity is the answer. Even U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio has [admitted](#) that it is inevitable, but there is no plan to ensure the global commons is protected at a time of rising extreme poverty and conflict along with growing climate change impacts.

Just like the global economy, multilateralism is fracturing, with the Trump administration exiting the United States from UN organizations such as the World Health Organization and defunding others like the World Food Program by its foreign assistance cuts.

Russia and China are expanding [alternative](#) organizations such as BRICS to de-dollarize and create alternative currency systems to the U.S. dollar. The mix of diminished institutions and great-power competition points to a deficit of needed cooperation when the next global pandemic, climate, or financial crisis erupts. Domestically, the discontent is

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US Focus to Western Hemisphere

Probability:



Trump asserted his own corollary to the Monroe Doctrine in his National Security Strategy, pairing it with his threats against cartels in Mexico and regime change in Venezuela — and steep tariffs and sanctions against Colombia and [Cuba](#) may be next.

Seeking to establish a dominant sphere of influence in the Western Hemisphere, while sidelining the United States' other regional commitments, has most Washington strategists scratching their heads. Certainly, the U.S. has ignored its neighbors for too long, but a mix of tariffs, threats, handouts to friendly leaders, and gunboat diplomacy can't turn the clock back to the 19th century when the United States was unrivaled in its hemisphere.

China understands better what Latin America wants: economic development. Despite worries about Chinese goods displacing local industries, [trade](#) between China, Latin America, and the Caribbean has “soared from \$12 billion in 2000 to \$315 billion in 2020,

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experts — the collapse of its economy — ultimately lead to Maduro's overthrow and to rampant inflation and shortages of food and other essentials, devastating the poor and middle classes. Trump appears to have no plan to help Venezuelans cope with the political instability should Maduro be ousted.

Third Nuclear Era

Probability:



2026 begins with the Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists' [Doomsday Clock](#) moved to just 89 seconds to midnight. Great-power competition is driving new nuclear risks, as existing powers such as the United States, Russia, and China seek to increase their stockpiles or carry out new tests, while at the same time, proliferation threats, from Iran to Japan, are unfolding in a third nuclear era.

AI, offensive cyber, and anti-satellite weapons are creating new vulnerabilities for nuclear powers. Gone is the Cold War-era balance of terror, as is the post-Cold War stasis and its

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China, are rising of the nuclear umbrella, suggested the possibility of limited nuclear war. This risk extends to lesser nuclear states — North Korea, which has massively built up its missile and nuclear force capabilities, and India and Pakistan, whose nuclear rivalry continues.

Faced with volatile security predicaments in the Middle East and East Asia and doubts about U.S. reliability, recent U.S. deals — nuclear submarines for South Korea, a US-Saudi civil nuclear program — raise concerns. Both may involve reprocessing nuclear fuel with which those countries could join Japan as virtual nuclear powers. South Korea is debating the virtues of nuclear weapons, and Japan is also rethinking its nuclear allergy. What could go wrong?

Gen Z Rebellion

Probability:



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immune.

Africa's predicament is even worse. The region contains 20 of 39 states the World Bank [dubbed](#) fragile or conflict affected in fiscal year 2026. These countries are replete with [internal clashes](#), ranging from civil wars to terrorist attacks. All have large unskilled youth bulges with few employment opportunities. On a more basic level, almost 600 million sub-Saharan Africans lack [access to electricity](#).

African states are also heavily burdened by foreign debt — [\\$746 billion cumulatively](#). And government debt in sub-Saharan Africa averages around [60%](#) of countries' gross domestic product. Approximately [57%](#) of Africans live in countries that spend more on external debt servicing than education or health care.

These youthful nations must find a path to development amid what some have dubbed a global [polycrisis](#) — a cascading set of intersecting problems. Those challenges include a growing North-South economic and technological divide; [declining aid](#); and navigating global financial negotiation to manage deepening debt issues, climate change, food insecurity, disease, and (not least) the risks to jobs from artificial intelligence.

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The Europeans alone are [not capable](#), nor is the United States under President Donald Trump willing, to provide Ukraine with the arms that could give it a fighting chance. Peace negotiations have been a never-ending merry-go-round, with Trump agreeing to Russian President Vladimir Putin's terms before pushing them on Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky, who musters European support for refusing them.

The recent U.S. National Security Strategy [targets](#) Europe, [forecasting](#) "civilizational erasure" for the continent and blaming it for Ukraine's resistance to a ceasefire. So far, Putin has not moved an inch to water down his terms. In the worst case, Trump will tire and dump the Ukraine problem on the Europeans, who won't be able to turn the tide and don't have much influence with the Kremlin.

With Russian forces advancing into Ukraine, Putin could become even greedier and less interested in settling. Russia is reportedly [stockpiling](#) long-range missiles that could devastate Ukraine. At best, Kyiv would impede a complete victory for Moscow, but it can't achieve a just peace without strong support from a united NATO. A peace settlement that endures and averts another conflict needs strong support from the United States. And although Trump says he wants a ceasefire, his real goal appears to be bilateral trade and

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countries to drop their climate efforts and concentrate on exploiting more fossil fuels.

To some extent, this has worked. Inside the United States, many companies are [scaling back](#) their earlier promises to fight climate change, and Microsoft founder Bill Gates wrote a remarkable [memo](#) that downgraded climate change's place in his philanthropic foundation's objectives list. There was [no mention](#) in the 2025 UN Climate Change Conference final statement of fossil fuels, much less a roadmap, thanks to Russia, Saudi Arabia, and other oil producers blocking one. And with China staying silent, the European Union showed itself ineffective in countering these anti-climate efforts.

The EU's silence "partly reflects the power shift in the real world," one analyst [told](#) the BBC, linking the emerging power of the Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa coalition to the decline of the EU. Even within the EU, there are concerns that meeting its aggressive 2040 emissions reduction target will aggravate the group's [weakening economic competitiveness](#).

At the UN climate conference, the goal of \$120 billion a year in climate financing for poor countries was [pushed back five years](#), from the initial suggested date of 2030 to 2035. This

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Despite hopes yet again for a “[new Middle East](#),” the region’s most enduring problems — Gaza and Iran — may move closer to renewed conflict than peace in 2026. The United States, mired in both conflicts, and with new security commitments to [Saudi Arabia](#) and [Qatar](#), is deepening its entrenchment in the region despite vowing in the new National Security Strategy to narrow its interests.

The first phase of the Trump-designed ceasefire plan for Gaza is already getting mugged by reality. Gaza is de facto [partitioned](#), with Israel controlling more than half of the territory and most Palestinians living in ruins in the other half. Meanwhile, Hamas is [refusing](#) to disarm and has reasserted its military and political presence. Fighting continues to flare up from [both sides](#).

There are indications the United States is considering redeveloping the Israeli-controlled half of Gaza. These realities impede further implementation of the peace plan, elements of which include an [international stabilization force](#) and a transitional, technocrat-run Palestinian administration.

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Against this backdrop, the International Atomic Energy Agency says Iran still has [enriched uranium](#), despite U.S. and Israeli bombings, and there are [signs](#) Tehran is continuing its nuclear program. It [renege](#)d on an agreement with the agency to resume external monitoring of its nuclear activities, and it has [rejected](#) U.S. offers of renewed nuclear talks (though it hints new talks are possible). Renewed Israeli and/or U.S. bombing of Iran is a looming prospect.

Artificial Intelligence: The Great Disruptor

Probability:



The transformational power of artificial intelligence cuts in different directions. On one hand, for example, AI could help [detect](#), [treat](#), and maybe even cure diseases such as cancer, Alzheimer's, and Parkinson's in the coming decade; on the other, it could be a new source of social disorder and contribute to democratic demise.

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investment is through debt. OpenAI doesn't [expect profits](#) until 2030; Anthropic hopes to break even by 2028.

Nor are many AI pilots reporting [return on their initiatives](#). The gap between massive investment and a dearth of revenues is sparking fears of a crash reminiscent of, if not worse than, the 2000 implosion of the dot-com bubble. There is also a [gap](#) between AI energy needs and available electricity, despite newly built power plants, leaving some data centers idle and driving up [electricity prices](#).

Risks don't end there. Some Americans, [including](#) Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang, think that China is winning the AI innovation race. China's open-source AI approach, as its popular DeepSeek chatbot demonstrated, results in models cheaper and [just as effective](#), though less technologically advanced, than U.S. products. While U.S. AI models seek superintelligence, China focuses on practical apps. These products may appeal to much of the Global South, which [already uses](#) China's digital infrastructure.

On top of these risks is the concern, as AI founders have voiced, that AI will render humans [extinct](#).

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factories out of China but use Chinese components. Though it encouraged such moves during the first Trump administration, the United States is [now seeking](#) to cut China out of these supply chains altogether.

Trump has [signed trade deals](#) with four member states of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), but the United States has yet to clarify final tariff levels. They will depend on how Trump decides the [rules of origin](#) — guidelines that determine, for instance, whether goods using Chinese components that were processed into final products in Vietnam (or other nations) and exported added enough local value to be tariffed at Vietnamese rates, or if they are designated as transshipped goods facing higher Chinese level tariffs.

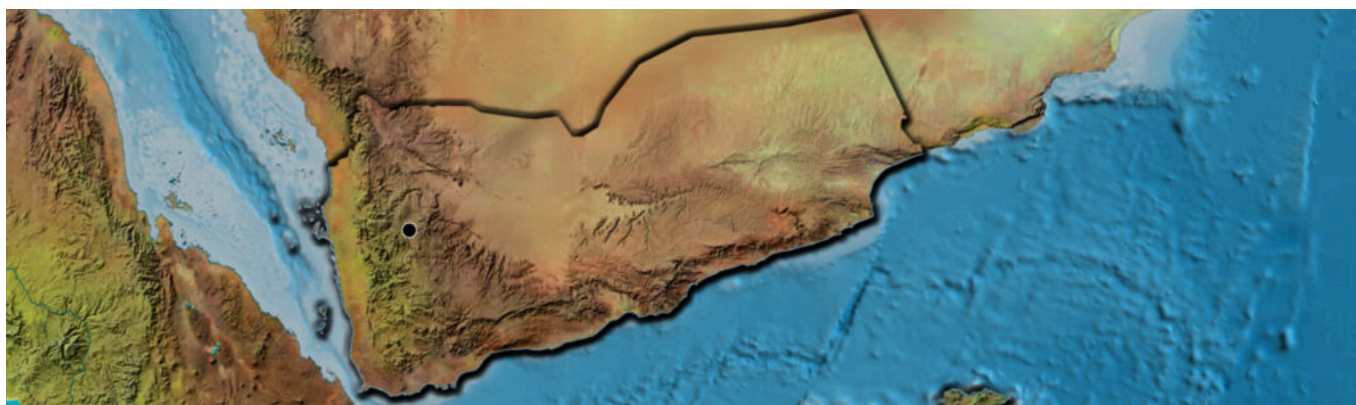
Current tariffs are already taking a toll on Asia, but if the United States requires a high level (say, 50% or more) of value added to avoid transshipment tariffs, Southeast Asia's economy could be hit hard, particularly if a flood of Chinese surplus goods shuts down ASEAN factories.

The locus of security conflict risks is South Asia. India-Pakistan tensions after recent [terrorist attacks](#) highlight a combustible situation. Both sides [claimed victory](#) after

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In short, tensions in the region remain high, with on-off ceasefires, and unresolved issues including simmering India-China border disputes suggest more conflict ahead.

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